

GGWP or another Respawn?

India will make the long journey to East Asia again, **hoping** to find what it missed in China

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Failure, as the old pros know, is a stern but honest pedagogue. The Indian esports contingent travelled to the 2022 Asian Games carrying hopes of 1.4 billion people. The part of the lot that came closest to glory was the League of Legends team — a run to the quarterfinals and an eventual fifth-place finish.

Four of the six members of that team comprise the new side — a nucleus of veterans with clicks and curses will now look to go second-time lucky, having secured a spot at the 2026 edition in Achi-Nagoya.

The roster comprising Akshaj Shenoy (Kat Bot, **pic above**), Aakash Shandilya (Infi), Sanindhya Malik (Deadcorporal), Mihir Ranjan (Lotus), Ahmed Shahid (Nero), and Rahul Bisht (Bob) entered the regional qualifiers with momentum on its side — clinching the National Esports Championships (NESC) 2026, the official national qualification tournament for the Asian Games 2026. The regional qualifiers featured 14 teams competing across a two-stage format: a round-robin Group Stage before advancing to the Split Stage, where the top-performing sides qualified for the Asiad.

Under the leadership of veteran Kat Bot [as the in-game leader (IGL)], India stormed past Jordan, Sri Lanka, and Kazakhstan to top the standings in the group-stage. Though losses to Vietnam, Hong Kong, and Saudi Arabia, wore its morale out. Yet, by the skin of its teeth — rather, mechanical keyboards — India scraped through to the main tournament.

The four warhorses from Hangzhou 2022 — Kat Bot,

Infi, Deadcorporal, and Lotus — have an idea for the battle that awaits this team — the old gods of the meta: Japan, Chinese Taipei, and Vietnam. But what sport has ever been without drama and the thrilling possibility of upsets after prayers whispered into headsets?

There is, however, more richness to this tapestry.

S8UL, India's only club partner at the Esports World Cup 2025, housed the LoL team along with two more athletes, among others: Gurashish Singh (Soul) and Prateek Bhaunt (B Haunt). The wheel of fortune, fuelled with hard work, also turned for them as the two made it to the Asiad for Tekken 8 and Street Fighter 6, respectively.

From a medal perspective, however, both would fall under a single category since the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) has combined Street Fighter, Tekken and King of Fighters into one medal title – Competitive Martial Arts (Team Competition).

From being a demonstrative event in 2018 to a full medal event five years later, esports has come a long way in making its presence known through the alleys of conventional sporting events.

Achi-Nagoya 2026 will feature 11 esports titles from September 23 to October 2: Gran Turismo 7, eFootball, Naraka: Bladepoint, Competitive Martial Arts, Puyo Puyo eSports, Pokémon Unite, Honor of Kings, PUBG Mobile, Identity V, Mobile Legends: Bang Bang, and League of Legends.

India will make the long journey to East Asia again, hoping to find what it missed in China, and only time will reveal if the pursuit ends in ggwp or another respawn.